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Mark A. Staal and Michael R. DeVries

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Mark A. Staal

OSS Consulting, LLC, Southern Pines, North Carolina

Michael R. DeVries

United States Army Special Operations Command, Ft. Bragg,
North Carolina

With increasing requirements for expeditionary support to military units, models of integrated and embedded psychology have emerged. Operational psychology represents one such model. Military operational psychologists receive specialized training, are embedded in operational units, and are employed to provide operational mission support to organizations and their personnel as opposed to providing individual health care per se. The following article describes the employment of military operational psychology and discusses its unique organizational and ethical challenges.

Keywords: operational psychology, military, national security, consultation, ethics

Most military psychologists perform traditional health care roles, operating from within their respective services' medical commands. However, with increasing requirements for expeditionary support due to conflicts in Afghanistan, Iraq, and elsewhere, models of integrated and embedded operational support have emerged. Military commanders quickly realized the value in integrating psychologists with their operational units. Moreover, as military missions have expanded, so too have the operational requirements for applying psychological consultation to purely operational activities.

Operational psychology traces its roots back to the mass military inductee screening conducted during World War I. This work expanded with the efforts of the Office of Strategic Services (OSS) during World War II. OSS psychologists were instrumental in the design and employment of assessment centers used to identify suitable candidates for work in intelligence, unconventional warfare, and espionage. Following the events of 9/11, the military and national intelligence apparatus was anxious to find answers and to prevent further attacks. As a result, many operational psychologists were pressed into service in a similar capacity to those supporting the OSS during the 1940s.

For readers less familiar with the operational psychology specialty, the following definition is provided: Operational psychology is "a specialty within the field of psychology that applies behavioral science principles to enable key decision makers to more effectively understand, develop, target, and/or influence an individual, group or organization to accomplish tactical, opera-

tional, or strategic objectives within the domain of national security or national defense" (Staal & Stephenson, 2013, p. 97). Operational psychologists provide a broad spectrum of operational support services to the military and other governmental agencies. Based on their operational alignment, military operational psychologists are typically assigned to operational commanders, as opposed to military treatment facilities or mental health clinics. These operationally focused practitioners advise commanders on personnel actions, organizational challenges, communication strategies, and specific operational lines of effort such as counterterrorism measures and counterintelligence activities. Most military operational psychologists start their professional lives as clinical providers. Based on interest and aptitude, these clinicians then voluntarily undergo specialized training in the areas of human performance, personnel selection, survival training, intelligence operations, information operations, and other areas (Air Force Special Operations Command, 2016; United States Air Force, 2013). Operational psychologists are employed across all military services as well as various public safety, law enforcement, and intelligence communities. Although the focus of their work differs from agency to agency, the core competencies for the specialty are similar (Staal & Stephenson, 2006; Williams & Johnson, 2006).

Military Operational Psychology Consultation

Military operational psychology practitioners often consult to clients who are third-party decision makers or organizations as opposed to individuals receiving personal services. In other words, the client is often not the subject of the services. This has the potential to create challenging ethical issues (see later discussion) to include issues of informed consent and dual agency. The following section provides examples of different military operational psychology consultation.

Consultation to Personnel Screening

The spectrum of consultative support to personnel job suitability screening includes hiring practices, selection decisions, placement, promotion, referral, retention, and entry into programs leading to

Mark A. Staal, OSS Consulting, LLC, Southern Pines, North Carolina; Michael R. DeVries, United States Army Special Operations Command, Ft. Bragg, North Carolina.

The views expressed in this article are those of the authors and do not necessarily reflect the official policy of the Department of Defense or other departments of the U.S. government.

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Mark A. Staal, OSS Consulting, LLC, 106 Selkirk Trail, Southern Pines, NC 28387. E-mail: ethicalpsych@gmail.com

advancement (e.g., apprenticeship, training, career development). Effective personnel assessment involves a systematic approach to gathering information about applicants' job qualifications and linking those qualifications with job requirements. These requirements are identified through a job analysis. Such analysis targets the identification of duties to be performed and the competencies needed for effective job performance (e.g., knowledge, skills, abilities, and other factors—KSAOs). Military operational psychologists are frequently called upon to complete a job analysis or competency analysis in the development of an assessment and selection program. Once developed, these psychologists may be instrumental in launching screening procedures for unit personnel as well as the validation of the screening process.

For example, a remotely piloted aircraft (RPA) unit, looking to improve the performance of its RPA operators, sought consultation from a military operational psychologist familiar with RPA operations. The initial consultation included an interview with unit leadership, used to clarify the goals and assumptions associated with the consultation. Clarifying the role of the operational psychologist, reporting requirements, and identifying the client and those impacted by the service is a critical first step. During this initial exchange, the consulting operational psychologist provided a brief description of the consultative process and set appropriate expectations for the outcome of the services. In this example, the operational psychologist recommended implementing a screening process prior to unit assignment in order to identify the most suitable candidates for RPA operations. The operational psychologist conducted a job analysis, during which experienced RPA aircrew were interviewed and observed conducting their duties. The relevant KSAOs were identified and a proposal for new screening procedures was drafted for unit leadership review and approval.

In addition to the implementation of the screening protocol, the operational psychologist made targeted training recommendations as well. Training cadre and unit leaders provided anecdotal evidence for specific performance concerns. This was used for exploratory interviews with RPA operators and the collection of performance data in the areas identified as most concerning. The data collected were then used to further validate and/or revise the concerns raised by unit leadership. Last, after consulting with training cadre further, specific recommendations for remediation and improved training were made to unit leadership.

Consultation to Military Training

As in the example above, operational psychologists are often employed by their units to assist in the development of training programs. The following is an example of operational psychology consultation to close quarter's battle (CQB) training. CQB training is the core small-team tactic used for building-clearing operations. When a threat is detected within a structure, the methods used for removing that threat have wide-reaching implications for stability operations and winning the hearts and minds in the local populace. From call-out procedures to how personnel gain access and move through the structure, the safety of the inhabitants and the clearing team is a constant consideration. Thus, CQB procedures must be trained repeatedly and with great precision.

CQB training requires tactical competence with multiple weapons systems, marksmanship proficiency, and a high level of team

coordination, effective communication, and astute management of energy (e.g., respiration, physical exertion, mental compartmentalization) by the operator. If performance decrements are identified in given trainees, an operational psychologist may be employed to work with these individuals on attentional focus, anxiety management, or other cognitive errors resulting in the performance concerns. In the following example, training cadre identified a trainee with multiple safety violations during live-fire CQB training events. Unit leadership requested operational psychology support in the hope that this trainee's performance could be improved sufficiently to keep him in training. The operational psychologist first met with the training cadre to clarify the nature of the performance issues and then conducted a series of trainee observations during CQB training scenarios. The operational psychologist worked with the trainee to identify cognitive errors that may have contributed to the performance decrements observed. Once identified, the operational psychologist and trainee designed a mental skills training plan to remediate and strengthen his performance. As an embedded unit member, the consulting operational psychologist was afforded the opportunity to assess the trainee's progress through periodic CQB training observations and instructor reports.

Military training can be highly stressful and dangerous, and operational psychologists play a crucial role in ensuring the safe conduct of training and the management of training stressors. Survival, Evasion, Resistance, and Escape (SERE) training is one such example. SERE training was developed to help service members cope effectively with, and inoculate them against, the effects of isolation and hostile captivity. Operational psychologists assist in monitoring both students and cadre to ensure the safety and effectiveness of the training. These psychologists monitor students for signs of poor coping and intervene as needed. They also provide assistance to SERE instructors, ensuring they are trained in behavioral drift, moral disengagement, and learning theory. They consult with supervising SERE cadre to promote the highest standards in instructor performance when interacting with SERE students.

Consultation to Military Operations

One of the unique capabilities of military operational psychology is the ability to provide direct support to military operations. One such example includes conducting an indirect assessment or "psychological profile" of a terrorist leader, terrorist cell, or violent extremist network. In this example, an operational psychologist was approached by a military intelligence unit who had been developing a briefing to unit leadership on current terrorist threats associated with an area of interest overseas. The threat model being developed was intended to guide deployed military commanders in assessing regional risk to military personnel. Based on the operational psychologist's data-analytic skills and familiarity with the terrorist elements in the area, she was able to collaborate with intelligence analysts in providing a predictive model of risk. Furthermore, she drafted recommendations to commanders in the field, assisting them in the deployment of their personnel based on regional risk factors and the probability of their future occurrence.

Interrogation consultation is another example of operational psychology support to military operations. In this example, a military operational psychologist was requested for consultation in

training new interrogators, analysts, and detention facility guards. The specific request concerned providing culture-specific sensitivity training, nested within an overarching desire for improved rapport between detained terrorist subjects and interrogation and detention staff. The perception of adversarial relations between both groups had reduced the effectiveness of information- and intelligence-gathering activities. The operational psychologist was asked to analyze the “human terrain” and group dynamics that were contributing to this negative outcome. Following focused interviews conducted by the psychologist with various staff elements and interrogation observations, the operational psychologist provided several recommendations to leadership that included an individualized coaching program for professional development among junior interrogators, sensitivity training for the detention guard staff, and the implementation of a detainee library program that included culturally appropriate literary works.

Ethical Considerations

Ethical issues are always a consideration when providing psychological services. They are, however, of particular concern in areas of emerging practice and when providing consultative services where informed consent and dual agency considerations are common. Operational psychology is no stranger to ethics-related controversy, and several notable exchanges have already taken place in addressing these concerns (Arrigo, Eidelson, & Bennett, 2012; Staal, 2018; Staal & Greene, 2015). The following provides a brief exposition of three common areas of ethical consideration facing operational psychologists.

Boundaries of Competence

Operational psychology, despite its long history within our nation’s national security and defense architecture, is a relatively new specialty area for practitioners. As a result, training in this area and an accompanying research literature have been outpaced by operational requirements and opportunities. Fortunately, the American Psychological Association’s (APA’s) ethical standards (APA, 2017) provide guidance in such circumstances (see 2.01e *Boundaries of Competence*). Under scope of competence, operational psychologists must consider several factors in assessing their ability to provide operational psychology consultation. This list of factors should include training and experience, availability of experienced operational psychologists for peer consultation, and the complexity of tasks to be performed. In the scenarios provided above, less experienced operational psychologists may find themselves adequately prepared to perform some operational psychology consultation work and not others. For example, conducting a job analysis and designing a personnel screening protocol may be something that even inexperienced operational psychologists are adequately prepared for; however, only more experienced operational psychologists may be properly prepared to conduct an indirect assessment of an extremist terror network and its leadership. If untrained, it is advised that the operational psychologist either decline the consultation request or conduct it only after he or she receives the requisite training and peer consultation. It should be noted that when conducting an indirect assessment, specific ethical considerations may apply (9.01 *Bases for Assessments* and 9.03 *Informed Consent in Assessments*). Moreover, specific guid-

ance for conducting indirect assessments of public figures (see the *Goldwater Rule*) have also been issued (McDaniel, 2016).

Informed Consent and Third-Party Consultation

Operational psychologists often consult to clients who are third-party decision makers or organizations as opposed to individuals receiving personal services. In other words, the client is often not the subject of the services. In some instances, the two may never meet, and thus it may be impossible or unreasonable to secure nonclients’ consent. The APA’s ethics code (APA, 2017) makes provisions for such limitations under 3.07 *Third-Party Requests for Services*, 3.10 *Informed Consent*, and 4.02 *Limits of Confidentiality*. When consulting with third-party clients, operational psychologists may be precluded by their organizational role or by law from providing informed consent to those affected by their services. When appropriate, they should inform such individuals prior to service delivery, and when unable to do so, they should take reasonable steps to minimize or mitigate potential harms. In our example of RPA candidates, informed consent regarding the proposed screening procedures, performance reporting requirements, and the potential impact of a poor screening outcome should be secured prior to the suitability assessment. In this case, the potential ethical dilemma between sharing information about the subject of services to a third-party client is easily avoided. However, in our example of the indirect assessment of a terrorist leader, securing informed consent may be impossible. Provision for this limitation is accounted for by the APA’s ethical standards.

Multiple Relationships and Dual Agency

Multiple relationships or dual agency is perhaps the most common ethical issue faced by military psychologists. Operational psychologists remain aware of these risks, and they should strive to avoid such relationships when they are assessed to be potentially exploitative. When they are unavoidable (or unlikely to be exploitative), operational psychologists should work to proactively mitigate risks to objectivity and effectiveness wherever possible. It should be noted that according to the APA ethics code (3.05 *Multiple Relationships*), dual relationships are not inherently unethical. There is an existing literature that addresses these potential pitfalls in military psychology (Johnson, 1995; Staal & King, 2000).

Operational psychology is a rapidly expanding specialty, constituting unique capabilities executed within a dynamic practice environment. It is not for everyone. The military itself requires many sacrifices to family and to career. As a uniformed service member, psychologists often deploy overseas to combat zone locations and are required to complete rigorous military training that may include SERE training, airborne “jump” school, or other combat support skills training. The military has its own culture as well. A myriad of acronyms, rank structure, compulsory dress and appearance regulations, and cultural mores and norms are fiercely enforced. For those who can tolerate these restrictions, there are an equal number of benefits, including the opportunity to take on leadership roles early in one’s career (running a mental health department), receiving world-class training, and practicing in a diverse and challenging work setting. Military psychologists typically receive competitive pay, regular promotion opportunities, chances to specialize, and a great pension.

For those interested in operational psychology specialization, the training and deployment opportunities only increase. Given recent controversies over interrogation support activities and the APA's Hoffman report, some psychologists may be concerned about supporting the military or joining its ranks as military psychologists or operational practitioners. Being a military psychologist and an operational psychologist can be challenging. Unlike many psychologists who are knowledgeable about ethics, military and operational psychologists are "ethics experienced." They face ethical challenges on a regular basis and, as a result, have learned how to apply the ethics code, community practice standards, and their own moral compass in navigating these potential dilemmas. To assist practitioners in this community, the development of professional practice guidelines has been recommended and is currently under way.

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